

Apollo 1

On Jan. 27, 1967, tragedy struck on the launch pad at Cape Kennedy during a preflight test for Apollo 204 (AS-204). The mission was to be the first crewed flight of Apollo, and was scheduled to launch Feb. 21, 1967. Astronauts Virgil Grissom, Edward White and Roger Chaffee lost their lives when a fire swept through the command module.

Mission Type

Human Space Flight

SCHEDULED TO LAUNCH

Feb. 21, 1967

Apollo 1 Tragedy

Jan. 27, 1967, tragedy struck on the launch pad at Cape Kennedy during a preflight test for Apollo 204 (AS-204). The mission was to be the first crewed flight of Apollo, and was scheduled to launch Feb. 21, 1967. Astronauts Virgil Grissom, Edward White and Roger Chaffee lost their lives when a fire swept through the command module, or CM.

The exhaustive investigation of the fire and extensive reworking of the Apollo command modules postponed crewed launches until NASA officials cleared them for flight. Saturn IB schedules were suspended for nearly a year, and the launch vehicle that finally bore the designation AS-204 carried a lunar module, or LM, as the payload, instead of a CM. The missions of AS-201 and AS-202 with Apollo spacecraft aboard had been unofficially known as Apollo 1 and Apollo 2 missions. AS-203 carried only the aerodynamic nose cone.

In the spring of 1967, NASA's Associate Administrator for Manned Space Flight, Dr. George E. Mueller, announced that the mission originally scheduled for Grissom, White and Chaffee would be known as Apollo 1, and said that the first Saturn V launch, scheduled for November 1967, would be known as Apollo 4. The eventual launch of

AS-204 became known as the Apollo 5 mission. No missions or flights were ever designated Apollo 2 or 3.

The second launch of a Saturn V took place on schedule in the early morning of April 4, 1968. Known as AS-502, or Apollo 6, the flight was a success, though two first-stage engines shut down prematurely, and the third-stage engine failed to reignite after reaching orbit.

NASA History

Remembering Apollo 1

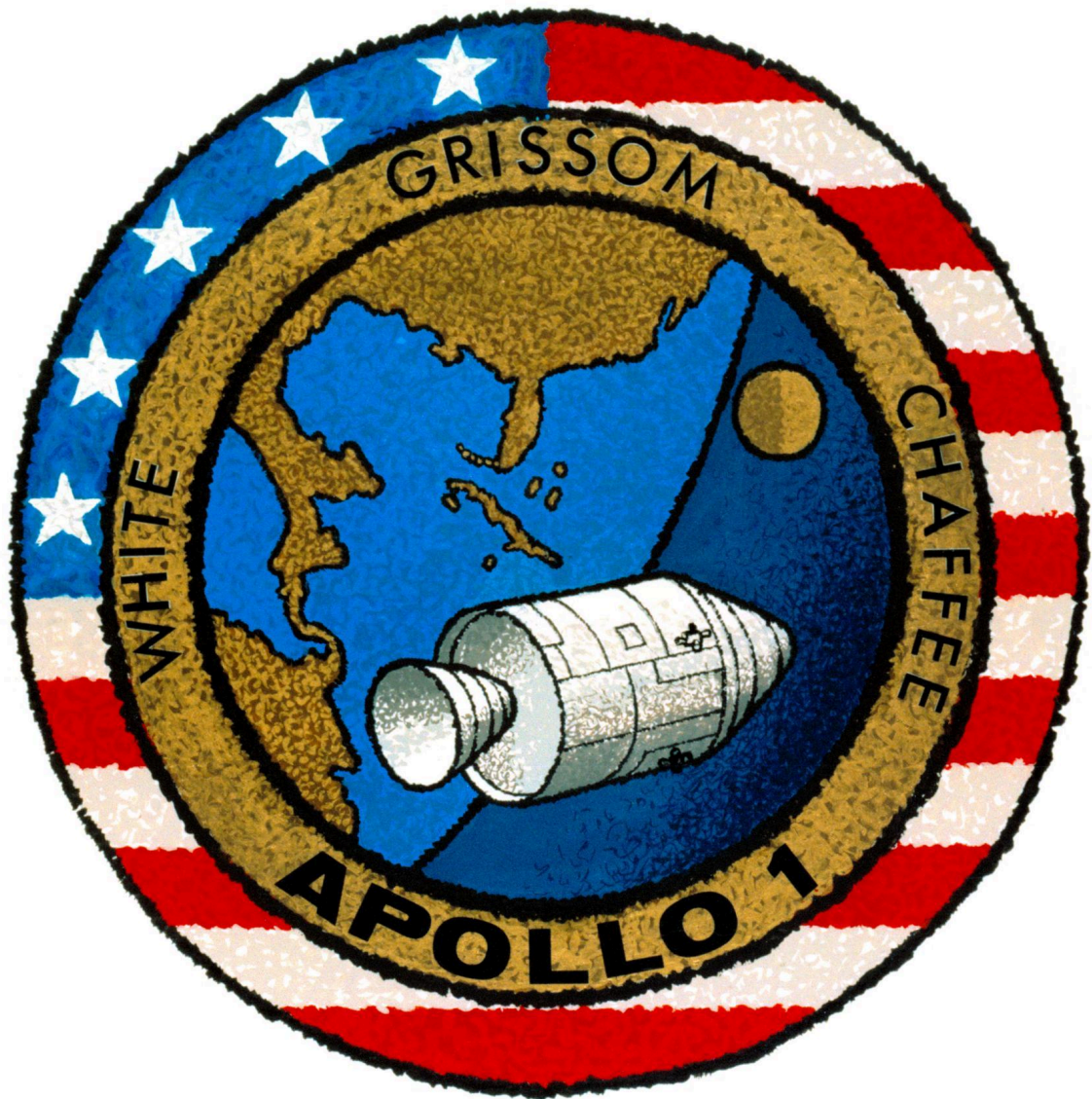
Read detailed biographies, reports, bibliographies, and other resources relating to the Apollo 1 tragedy that took the lives of Gus Grissom, Ed White, and Roger Chaffee.

Learn More



Manned Spacecraft Center Director Robert R. Gilruth (far right) introduces the Apollo 1 crew during press conference in Houston. Sitting next to Gilruth are (from left) astronauts Roger Chaffee, Edward H. White II, and Gus Grissom. (1966)

NASA



Insignia for the NASA Apollo 1 mission, the first manned Apollo flight. Crew members were astronauts Virgil I. u0022Gusu0022 Grissom, Edward H. White II, and Roger B. Chaffee. (1966)

NASA

Crew

Virgil I. Grissom

Edward H. White

Roger B. Chaffee

Backup Crew

Walter M. Schirra Jr.

Donn F. Eisele

Walter Cunningham

Payload

Spacecraft-012

Apollo Pad Fire

Emergency Transmission: Jan. 27, 1967; 6:31:05 p.m. EST

Launch Complex 34

Saturn-IB AS-204

CSM-012

Houston We Have a Podcast: Apollo 1 Fire

Expert guests from the Apollo program reveal more behind the challenges faced to successfully land humans on the Moon in less than three years after the tragic Apollo 1 fire. The panel was recorded on January 24, 2017.